

UK Construction SMEs: AI Adoption Journeys, 2026

Three evidence-bounded implementation journeys



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EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Follow workflow change, not product announcements

Three evidence bundles show different parts of implementation. They are kept separate by organisation, research method and outcome type; missing stages are not reconstructed.

90 approx. employees Cast Consultancy SME case	3 case bundles SME, large-company and prototype	0 pooled ROI claims Transfer the design, not another result
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Comparison frame

Stage	Question
Problem	Which workflow or capability gap triggered the work?
Selection	How were requirements, users and boundaries defined?
Pilot	What was tested, by whom and with what controls?
Adaptation	What changed after feedback or failure?
Outcome	What was measured, reported or left unknown?

01 CAST CONSULTANCY

A live workflow anchored tool-based upskilling

Journey point	Published evidence
Starting point	A roughly 90-person consultancy needed to understand the Gateway 2 workflow.
Implementation	A group of about 10-15 project managers used a tool-based learning approach.
Feedback	Users raised practical issues and fed them back to the provider.
Reported outcome	Qualitative confidence, capability, collaboration and critical-review gains.
Boundary	No audited time, cost, quality, safety or compliance result.

Transfer lesson

Tie upskilling to a live, bounded workflow. Keep users, reviewers and the provider close enough for problems to change the implementation.

The case supports an implementation design, not a productivity claim.

1. DSIT supporting case studies - Cast Consultancy

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a26e9cc2cdcfdb7436ac0e6/supporting_case_studies.pdf

2. Building Safety Regulator - higher-risk building control approval

<https://www.gov.uk/guidance/building-control-approval-for-higher-risk-buildings>

02 CONSTRUCTIONCO

Consultation and governance followed an earlier setback

Journey point	Published evidence
Starting point	A previous system struggled after limited consultation; AI activity was fragmented.
Selection	A cross-functional group used MoSCoW requirements and identified bounded use cases.
Controls	Confidence levels, data leakage, legal requirements and strategy were made visible.
Reported outcome	Legal document review reportedly fell from about 60 to 15 minutes.
Boundary	Several-thousand-employee housebuilder; estimate was self-reported and not independently evaluated.

Transfer lesson

Start with users and requirements before tool choice. A failed digital implementation can be relevant evidence about consultation and change management without becoming an AI outcome.

Do not transfer the reported time saving to an SME business case.

1. CIPD/IFOW - ConstructionCo AI journey
<https://www.cipd.org/uk/knowledge/case-studies/construction-company-ai/>

03 BID-PREPARATION PROTOTYPE

Technical performance is one part of a tender system

Journey point	Published evidence
Problem	Repeated extraction, retrieval and drafting work in construction bid preparation.
System	Requirement extraction, semantic retrieval, a structured repository and draft generation.
Reported result	96.25% average F1 in the reported quantitative test.
What remains	Evidence approval, commercial challenge, delivery validation and submission assurance.
Boundary	Two-case research prototype; not a UK SME field outcome, tender win rate or ROI.

Transfer lesson

Evaluate extraction separately from evidence matching, drafting, specialist review and the final submission decision.

A high extraction score cannot validate an unsupported statement or make a commercial commitment.

1. Generative AI model for construction bid preparation
<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/15623599.2026.2629023>

04 CROSS-CASE SYNTHESIS

Five lessons survive the evidence boundaries

- Begin with one defined workflow and a named operational owner.
- Include the people who do and review the work before selecting the tool.
- Keep source traceability, exception handling and human override visible.
- Measure correction and review effort alongside preparation time.
- Transfer implementation design, not another organisation's outcome.

Sources

1. DSIT supporting construction cases

https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/media/6a26e9cc2cdcfdb7436ac0e6/supporting_case_studies.pdf

2. CIPD/IFOW ConstructionCo case

<https://www.cipd.org/uk/knowledge/case-studies/construction-company-ai/>

3. Construction bid-preparation research prototype

<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/abs/10.1080/15623599.2026.2629023>

4. DBT - Understanding technology adoption among UK SMEs

<https://www.gov.uk/government/publications/understanding-technology-adoption-among-uk-smes>

Secondary evidence only. No pooled ROI, vendor ranking or reconstructed success story.